

Chapter

Awaken the Power Within — Balancing Mahakali, Mahalakshmi and Mahasaraswati



Introduction: A Discourse Beyond Time

Acharya Upendra Ji gave this discourse at a Kali temple. The subject he usually teaches for a hundred hours over a twenty-one-day camp — the Durga Saptashati — had to be compressed today into about an hour:

"Our record is speaking for 17 hours straight — without a break. There is no speech in it, no bhajan, nothing else — only knowledge, only awakening. This is what is called the 'timeless state' (*kālātīta avasthā*) — where the clock and time no longer bind you."

Even in this short time he drew a large picture: the three goddesses of the Durga Saptashati — **Mahakali, Mahalakshmi and Mahasaraswati** — are in truth the three gunas of nature; from these gunas the individual, society, the varnas and religions are formed; and the success of a life, an institution and a nation rests on the balance of all three. At the end he turns especially to the power of Mahakali — the power of self-protection, physical strength and discerning courage.

1. Childhood Questions: Why the Deities Are Symbols

Acharya Ji's spiritual journey began with questions. Like other Maharashtrian families, his home recited the Ganapati Atharvashirsha:

"In that recitation, 'saiṣā gaṇeśavidyā' was said again and again. So I would ask — what is this Ganesh vidya? Why has Ganesh Ji been given a trunk like an elephant? But no one could give a straight answer. They would just say — 'That's how it is, do the puja.'"

"How many parents can truly answer these questions? Most don't know themselves. They say — if you have faith, just do it. And in the name of this faith, all kinds of blind faith also creep in."

Shiva, Parvati, Durga, Ganapati — one family, so why are Shaivas, Shaktas, Vaishnavas and Ganapatyas separate sects? These questions, which arose when he was ten or twelve, became the basis of his search. And the search led to this answer:

"All these forms, all these symbolic creations — they were all imagined because we cannot see that formless One. So it has been presented in a form — so that we can understand."

sādhakānām hitārthāya brahmaṇo rūpakalpanā

"The forms of the formless Brahman are conceived
only for the welfare of the seekers."

— Scriptural saying

Only when the symbol is understood is the worship complete:

"What is Ganapati's big belly, 'mahākāya', for? He did not get fat just by eating modaks. It tells me that I should be able to digest my joys and sorrows."

"Ganapati is the symbol of discerning intelligence (**viveka-buddhi**). And that mouse — it is the desires and cravings inside all of us. They eat up our time. Discerning intelligence is the power that can steer these desires in the right direction."

The forms of the deities point toward the truth; when the meaning of the pointer opens up, worship becomes knowledge.

2. From Form to Formless: How Long Should Idol Worship Last?

How long is idol worship necessary? Acharya Ji answers from the Gita:

**bahūnām janmanām ante jñānavān mām
prapadyate
vāsudevaḥ sarvam iti sa mahātmā sudurlabhaḥ**
"At the end of many births, the wise one attains Me
— the great soul who knows 'Vasudeva is
everything' is very rare."
— Bhagavad Gita 7.19

"If you are a Shaiva, then 'Shiva is everything'; if you worship the Devi, then the Devi is everywhere — that is how you should see. When you see like this, the seeker is no longer a seeker; in that very moment he becomes a mahatma."

But how hard it is to see God everywhere, he shows with examples from life:

"It means you should see God even in your enemy. In a mother-in-law and daughter-in-law quarrel — each should see God in the other. Yes, even if she comes at you with a rolling pin in her hand! ... If there is a theft at home — you should see God even in that thief. This is described as the last step of the spiritual journey. Until this state is reached, idol worship is necessary."

Tirtha and Feeling

The idol needs no bath, clothes or food offering; worship is a medium for expressing our devotion. Its test comes at the end of the puja:

"Once I have accepted it as God, the water of the abhishek I performed — that tirtha — has come out after touching God. Then when I take that tirtha into my body, my feeling should be that before any medicine, this will heal me."

"If this faith did not awaken in you — that this tirtha is truly divine — then it will remain just a ritual. Now, I am not saying do only this and abandon science. No — science is also necessary, but along with it you need this feeling."

The Thief Is Also a Lesson

A police inspector asked: if everyone is a form of Vasudeva, should we let an accused man go? Acharya Ji's answer was — no; but find your own lesson in that event too:

"You should see: 'God has come into my life in the form of this person to teach me some lesson, or to play some leela.' ... This does not mean you should not go to the police station — that is not what is said. But he came to teach some lesson."

"You must have stolen — stolen time. When you went to your job, you took eight hours' salary and sat chatting for two hours. ... You have stolen something, which is why that thief came to your house today to teach you this lesson."

And if not even that, then perhaps the Devi is teaching you that "you know how to earn, but you don't know how to safeguard it."

Idol Worship Is a Practice Match

"Until when should idol worship be done? Until you are able to do it for the living image. It is a practice match. True food-giving, clothes-giving — where were you supposed to give this? To the public, to people. It was to be given to the living Devi and the living God."

**patraṁ puṣpaṁ phalaṁ toyaṁ yo me bhaktyā
prayacchati
tad ahaṁ bhakty-upahṛtam aśnāmi
prayatātmanaḥ**

"Whoever offers Me with devotion a leaf, a flower, a fruit or water — that loving offering of the pure-hearted I accept."

— Bhagavad Gita 9.26

"Work itself is worship. Don't they say that work is my puja? Until you reach the living image, you need the idol."

He explains **paryupāsana** by breaking the word apart — **pari** (utterly), **upa** (near), **āsana** (sitting):

**ananyāś cintayanto mām ye janāḥ paryupāsate
teṣāṁ nityābhiyuktānāṁ yoga-kṣemaṁ vahāmy
aham**

"Those who worship Me, thinking of Me with undivided devotion — for them, ever united with Me, I Myself carry their welfare and security."

— Bhagavad Gita 9.22

"I have to sit near God — who is in the form of people — through the service of people. ... Krishna says — while you are alive, while you live, I will take care of your welfare. ... If you are an entrepreneur, become a good entrepreneur, give a good product. That will be your puja. Lakshmi Ji will come to you on her own."

"This does not mean give up that puja. But the form of puja should gradually move in another direction — toward the formless. First toward all living people, and then beyond them as well."

3. "Cut Down Kali": Seeing Beyond the Image

The most beautiful example of this journey is Ramakrishna Paramahansa, a devoted worshipper of Kali:

"In his Bengali he kept saying again and again — 'I am not getting the experience, I am not getting the experience. I worship you so much, I do idol worship too, so why am I not getting the experience?' His guru (Totapuri) gave only this answer — 'When you cut down Kali, you will attain Kali.'"

"That is, don't stop at the idol; look beyond the idol. You should see both the form and the formless together."

The same applies to the guru:

"If the guru is seen only as a body, it is of no use, because this body will perish one day. The guru-principle that speaks from behind the guru — do you see both together?"

What that formless is, he explains with the example of a good and a bad person:

"When both die, does my good action come from that dead body? And does a bad action come from the other's dead body? No. ... So whatever was manifesting through both while they were alive — that was the formless reality. That is what must be known. That is spirituality; that is the study of the Self."

"When it was said 'cut down Kali', its meaning is not to smash the idol, but to learn to see beyond it."

The Durga Saptashati itself teaches this. After describing many goddesses — Aindri, Maheshwari and others — the Devi proclaims in the battle with Shumbha and Nishumbha:

"'I alone am One; do not see me as separate.' This is the awakening that began in Antar Yog."

4. Three Goddesses, Three Gunas

Three goddesses appear in the Durga Saptashati — Mahakali, Mahalakshmi and Mahasaraswati. Acharya Ji's core principle is:

"Work cannot be done by taking only one. If you take up only Goddess Kalika and leave the others, there will be imbalance. That is why it is necessary to understand the entire fourteenth chapter of the Bhagavad Gita."

The Meaning of Guna: A Binding Rope

"If you look in a Sanskrit dictionary, it becomes clear that one meaning of the word guna is 'rope', 'thread'. These three ropes are what bind us. ... In the Gita, the Lord says that even sattva guna binds. Whether it is a golden chain or an iron chain, if it keeps you bound, neither is of any use."

Sattva brings knowledge, happiness, dispassion and discernment — but one can become attached even to these:

"If I become attached to that knowledge — that I must read again and again, read and read — then my next birth will be in a library. ... 'Guru, Guru, Guru' — if I keep chanting only this, then fine, I will have to take birth again to serve the guru."

All Three Are Needed, Each in Its Place

"If some action is to be done, rajo guna is needed. If knowledge is to be gained, sattva guna is needed. And if one needs rest, or something must be destroyed, dissolved, then tamo guna is needed too. ... That is, all three gunas are needed together. One only has to understand which guna should be dominant in which place."

The Colours of the Goddesses

The colours of the goddesses' garments are the colours of these gunas:

- **Mahasaraswati — white, sattva:** "The colour of sattva is white, so Saraswati's garment is white."
- **Mahalakshmi — red, rajas:** "Pressure rises — on the heart, on blood pressure, on the breath in all the running around — all this is the power of rajas. Its colour is said to be red. That is why Lakshmi's colour is red."
- **Mahakali — black, tamas:** "The colour of tamas is said to be black, so she stays in black garments."

He also says this lightly — no woman keeps saris of only one colour, so "whoever conceived this changed only the colours of their sari borders. In reality there are these three colours, and these three colours are the colours of the three gunas."

5. From Three Gunas, Four Varnas

Acharya Ji goes on to explain that the four varnas are formed from these same three gunas:

**cātur-varṇyaṁ mayā sṛṣṭaṁ guṇa-karma-
vibhāgaśaḥ**

"The four varnas were created by Me according to
the division of guna and karma."

— Bhagavad Gita 4.13

"He did not use the word 'jati'; he used the word
'varna'. We had only lineage, gotra and varna. ... From
the word 'casta' came the word 'caste', and it was
imposed on us. ... The idea that a potter's son must only
be a potter, a king's son must only be a king — this was
not in our tradition. Our society was based on guna."

The Parable of the Traffic Signal

He explains the four varnas through the story of a traffic
signal:

- **Brahmin (white, sattva):** the one who researched and
designed the red, green and orange lights and the zebra
crossing — "consider him the brahmin of that field. ... But
that brahmin will be a person who understood the
signal's rule and will stop his own car too. ... The brahmin

who only gives discourses, who is a guru but does not follow it himself — he is useless."

- **Kshatriya (pink, sattva + rajas):** sattva lacks the power to compel others. Then someone says — "I too will follow this system and make people follow it. But in return I want a little honour and wealth. ... I will mix my white and red, and then I will become the pink kshatriya." And this is not wrong — "**dharmasya mūlam arthaḥ**", wealth is the root of dharma.
- **Vaishya (brown/maroon, rajas + a little tamas):** the one who liked the king's rajas but not the brahmin's thinking — "where will his attention mostly be? On wealth. If public welfare happens, that is secondary." (But one who learns Shri Vidya and adds sattva to the worship of Lakshmi "is a different person.")
- **Servant (black, tamas):** "The moment the owner leaves, the foreman leaves, he goes out to smoke a bidi. Whether he is in America, Mexico, England or India — the worker's tendency will be the same. ... This is neither good nor bad."

All Four Are Needed

"If I understand this, love begins between us. ... There is a temple — so a priest is needed. But if there is only a priest and no one else, will the temple run? ... And finally, if everything is done but there is no one to clean, then? So all four are needed, aren't they?"

"If everyone says 'I have become an architect', then all houses will remain only on paper."

"Whether you have to run an institution or a nation, these four varnas are needed, and within them these three gunas should be in the right proportion. ... But all this should happen under the guidance of the guru. ... It is not said 'stay subordinate'; it is said 'live with love'."

6. Rama and Hanuman: "What Is Our Relationship?"

Acharya Ji sees the solution to varna conflict in a story from the Ramayana. Once Shri Rama asked his supreme servant Hanuman — "What is the relationship between you and me?" Hanuman Ji answered in one stroke, on three levels.

From the dualistic view — master and servant:

"You have asked about my relationship with you, so you must have asked from a dualistic feeling. Then you are my master and I am your servant. This is certain. In this birth I am not going to come and sit on your throne. I know my limits. I was born for that work."

From the qualified non-dual view (Vishishtadvaita) — the whole and the part:

"Had it been said in English, he would say — 'You may be the whole, sir, but I am also a part.' Don't consider me incomplete, don't consider me zero. ... You may be the ocean, $H_2O + NaCl$ — but I too am a drop. The only difference is that ships cannot sail in my one drop. But when little drops like me come together, only then does your ocean form."

"If you are fire, I am its spark. If each spark separates and leaves, your fire does not remain. ... If you are king, it is because soldiers like us are here that you sit on this throne as king."

From the non-dual view (Advaita) — one Self:

"If you asked from the level of the Self, from the non-dual feeling, then you and I are exactly the same, and we are that one Self. I do not consider you and me separate. This is my firm conviction; this is our relationship."

This is the awakening Acharya Ji brings to people of all four varnas — fulfil your role wholeheartedly, but don't be locked in it:

"If you are a servant, it is not that you must remain a servant all your life. You too can become an owner. ... But when you become an owner, become a proper provider. If you want to become a teacher of awakening, become one. So in the varna system anyone can move up or down."

7. Tendency, Not Person: Manusmriti and the Conflict of Gunas

Acharya Ji opens the meaning of the disputed Manusmriti verses — pouring oil in the ears of a shudra who hears the Vedas and so on — through the lens of the gunas:

"First one must realise that they were talking about the four varnas, that is, the gunas — about the shudra tendency. The shudra tendency can arise in a brahmin's mind too, in a kshatriya's mind, in anyone's mind."

"'If he hears the Vedas with a shudra tendency, pour oil in his ears' — this means: do not teach the Vedas to one with such a tendency. ... He will take this knowledge but use it as black magic. ... They were not talking about any particular person or any community."

Drop the Vibration of "We Are Backward"

"Atrocities were committed on us thousands of years ago, but should this end now or not? ... If a large part of society keeps sending out the same vibration again and again — 'we are backward, backward' — this country cannot move forward."

"If you came to learn 'aham brahmāsmi', became Brahman, then the brahmin feeling awakened in you — so how are you backward? ... If, after going to the guru, that Brahman-feeling did not come into you, then that guru himself was wrong."

Acharya Ji calls today's problem political — colleges with only 200 seats are built for 2,000 students, creating "artificial supply and demand", and "we are made to fight among ourselves in the name of reservation." As a guru, his objection is not to the facility but to irresponsibility:

"The problem is not that you get a facility. That is the king's problem. ... As a guru, my problem is that you cannot cause harm in society. ... But if in this birth you dug a pothole in the road, did not do your work properly, the guru will scold you."

The Conflict of Gunas

Why does conflict arise? Because the gunas by nature oppose one another — this is called **guṇavṛtti virodha**, the conflict of the gunas:

"I am running and also sleeping; I am sitting for meditation and also running — this cannot happen. At one time only one guna is dominant. This is called the conflict of the gunas."

"If you do a lot of work at home, what will they say? 'How much will you work, rest a little.' If you are resting, they will say — 'Get up and do some work.'"

"The scriptures say that the ego of knowledge comes quickly; that of action comes later. The brahmin varna was one; it developed a separate ego. That is why the problems arose."

The saints gave the solution:

"All the saints said, 'Become beyond the gunas, my friend.' If you go beyond the gunas, you can rise above this problem. We need all the gunas. He too is a human being and this one too is a human being."

8. A World Guru Through Balance: The Rosary and the Spear

Acharya Ji distinguishes between 'Sanatan' and 'Hindu':

"Sanatan means eternal. ... Sanatan means the dharma of nature's laws that have existed since the beginning of the world. Hindu is considered the first to emerge from it — a sattva-dominant dharma."

The forgiveness of sattva is our strength, but in excess it becomes weakness:

"Forgiveness, compassion, love — we have all of this in abundance. ... Crimes keep happening, yet we keep forgiving. This is the result of this guna."

What the excess of any one guna looks like, he says by applying it to himself:

"If only tamas becomes dominant in me, there will be a problem. ... I will only wield the sword on others, I won't forgive. ... If I become too rajasic, I will work only for profit and self-interest without thinking of others. And if I become only sattvic, actions will become very few. ... A state of 'let whatever happens, happen' will arise."

"If India is to become a world guru, the balance of these three gunas will be essential. Being only a sattvic Hindu will not do. ... Shishupala had the boon of forgiveness up to a hundred offences, but after a hundred offences the discus did fly, didn't it! So Hindu dharma has to understand that the power of Mahakali — the power to wield weapons — must be in me too."

The same applies at home:

"'The child doesn't listen, the child doesn't listen' — merely saying this is not enough for a mother. Excessive attachment is not good. ... 'lālayet pañca varṣāṇi, daśa varṣāṇi tāḍayet' — fondle for five years, discipline for ten — at that time the power of Kali should have come into you."

The Strength Within Our Daughters

He agrees with the demand for the harshest punishment for those who deceive daughters, but turns the question inward:

"But the question is — were your daughters first taught brahmacharya? ... Ravana abducted Sita, but afterwards she does not say, 'Now this king is good, I will go with him.' Her own observance of virtue — everything was there, which is why Ravana could not touch her."

"In the Durga Saptashati, Shumbha and Nishumbha summon the Devi. ... But her answer remains — no, I will marry only the one who defeats me in battle. Has this strength been given to our daughters?"

"Love is love; it can happen with anyone; it is a karmic bond. ... But has she been taught to recognise whether the person in front of her is an asura or not? Are there asuras in our own religion too, or not?"

And balance is needed from both sides — the faiths where tamas and rajas dominate will also "have to understand that you too should not always draw the sword. You will have to learn to forgive. Only if this comes can we become a world guru."

Not by the Weapon, but by the Scripture

"We have not come to become world conquerors by the strength of the sword. What is the prophecy? India will become a world guru. ... Then should the guru be the ideal first, or the disciple? The guru. ... The guru is called 'Mauli' (mother). Do we look at them today through a mother's eyes?"

"We will win not by **shastra** (weapon) but by **shāstra** (scripture). To win means a war will certainly happen. But winning 'by scripture' means — just as Valya became Valmiki, some people should be transformed by words alone. ... The one who does not listen, like Duryodhana, will have to be shown the sword."

And the guru's role is like Krishna's — that of a guide, not a fighter:

"What does Krishna say to Arjuna? 'I will not fight myself. This is a dispute between you and the Kauravas.' ... Krishna went as a messenger of peace — 'At least give them five villages.' Every persuasion was tried. Now go to war. But you have to fight; I am only the guide."

9. Phalashruti: The Union of Knowledge and Science

Everyone prays in their own way — some bow, some ask in dua, some make the sign of the cross. Acharya Ji's test is simple:

"The result (**phalashruti**) must come, mustn't it? I do Shiva sadhana — does my disease go or not? This is the most important thing. ... If it goes, then your going to church is right. If it goes by doing sadhana here, then coming to the temple is right."

"In 'Antar Yog' we have designed such sadhanas whose result is received 'here and now'."

"God made man. Man made science."

"God made man. Man developed science. So who made science? God Himself. The problem is that man came in between. ... Now he feels that God and science are enemies of each other."

"When the gurukul system existed, all three were taught together — knowledge of dharma, science and the knowledge of reality (**tattvajñāna**)."

jñānam te 'haṁ sa-vijñānam idaṁ vakṣyāmy
aśeṣataḥ
yaj jñātvā neha bhūyo 'nyaj jñātavyam avaśiṣyate
"I shall tell you this knowledge in full, together with
science (**vijñāna**), knowing which nothing more
remains to be known here."
— Bhagavad Gita 7.2

"Notice — Krishna says 'knowledge together with science'. ... Were our ancient rishis and munis scientists or not? Yes, they were scientists."

From the Known to the Unknown: Om Is an "X"

"Just as in mathematics we assume 'X'. ... Before X, all the other known numbers and equations are given.

'From the known to the unknown' — that is its meaning. Omkara is just like that. Omkara cannot be seen; it is formless. But its results, its nature, its effects can be seen. ... Our rishis gave that 'X' the name 'Om'."

"Whatever the name, the answer stays the same. Call God by any name — the answer will be the same, you will find the same Supreme."

From Result to Trust, From Trust to Faith

"The Shiva Purana says that by doing Shiva sadhana my disease should be cured, doesn't it? And this cure should show in a blood test. ... If it shows, my trust will grow. This is what is called faith (*shraddhā*). But if there is no result at all, it becomes blind faith."

"First let the result be seen through science. After the result comes, trust grows; after trust grows, faith grows; and when faith grows, the Gita says — '*śraddhāvānl labhate jñānam*', the one with faith attains knowledge. ... To show proof, the guru must be that powerful. And his language must be scientific."

Ramakrishna Paramahansa did the same — a salt doll went to measure the depth of the ocean and dissolved in it:

"To explain the formless, he spoke in the language of 'chemistry' itself. ... If I had no knowledge of chemistry, I would not have understood this example either."

Answers for the 99 Percent

Travelling across India, Acharya Ji saw society in four parts:

"The fourth type is the seeker, the true devotee — such people are only one percent. The remaining 99 percent are divided into three groups. The first group is the atheists. The second group is the rationalists, who always expect answers and logic. And the third group is the superstitious."

"If we ignore them and focus only on the one percent, then how can we become a world guru?"

"What will happen in Kali Yuga? It will be an age of machines, an age of intellect. That is why rationalist people have increased greatly. They are not all wrong. The problem is that we are unable to give them answers."

Remembering Swami Chinmayananda's words — that one day some guru would have to answer in the language of science — Acharya Ji began opening up the symbolic meaning of the scriptures:

"'Shiva Ji said to Parvati' — its real meaning is that my own Self spoke with my own mind and intellect. ... Mahishasura means the ego inside me. He keeps changing 7–8 forms. ... These are all symbolic stories. They do not happen somewhere else; they happen within."

The Secret of the Coconut

"The brown outer covering of the coconut ... is the symbol of rajas and tamas. ... That is, from rajo guna and tamo guna the hard-shelled ego is born. ... When we pull out its tuft, that is the renunciation of desires. Then the three eyes inside become visible. ... Breaking it forcefully means the ego is not destroyed easily; it has to be broken, and only then will the white appear inside. ... The sweet water that comes out of it is the knowledge of reality; it is the Ganga of knowledge."

"But people become egoistic about that very thing — 'we broke two hundred coconuts'."

10. Mahakali: The Sword of Discernment

At the end, since he is in a Kali temple, Acharya Ji turns to Mahakali:

"Goddess Kali should awaken in all of us — this is what I say. ... She also has the power of destruction. She bears weapons; she is of a very modern form."

"She is not some external woman; she is me, my own nature."

The Garland of Heads: Slain Faults

"The garland of heads (**muṇḍamālā**) does not mean only the destruction of external enemies; it is the removal of the faults within me. If I had miserliness and that miserliness was slain, I will become generous. ... The first focus is to turn our first attention to the habit of slaying faults, and when needed, to also know how to destroy the outer enemy."

An Eye in the Weapon

"Kali has a weapon, but that weapon also has an eye. She knows whom to strike and how much to strike; where to love and where not. ... There should be a rosary (mālā) in one hand and a spear (bhālā) in the other — so the gurus say."

"Did Arjuna know how to wield weapons or not? He did. But the problem was that he could not understand on whom to use them. ... So first learn to wield the weapon on your own faults. That is where the radiance of Mahakali appears."

And the target of every discourse is the listener himself:

"People have this illusion — 'Oh! This applies to our uncle. This teaching is for my wife.' ... But the truth is that every discourse is only for you."

Physical Strength First

"That Mahakali power is the symbol of self-protection, of body-awareness. So first of all our body should be strong. ... Someone became intelligent, became a scientist, created formulas — but some strong person came and pointed a gun, and that knowledge becomes useless in a moment."

In the Chandogya Upanishad, the rishi Uddalaka showed this to Shvetaketu by making him fast for fifteen days — "annamayam hi somya manah", the mind is made of food:

"When he fasts for fifteen days, his body becomes weak; he cannot even recite one mantra properly. ... So Kali worship is the first worship. The first episode (of the Durga Saptashati) is that of Kali."

Protecting the Institution and the Nation

"So first of all secure your copyrights, trademarks and patents — that too is a form of Kali power."

"Just as in ancient times, when a yajna was to be performed, the rishis invoked Shri Rama and Lakshmana to protect it with bow and arrows. ... Today the police, the army and our security guards do this work. And this is Kali power."

"If the nation does not survive, dharma will not survive either. And when dharma does not survive, culture will not survive either. ... Because they stay awake at the border at night, I can sleep peacefully here. This is the importance of Kali."

Mahakali in Every Woman

"A woman too is a form of Mahakali. So for the protection of her virtue, for her own protection, she must first practise self-defence. ... A mother should give this training to her daughter from childhood. ... In schools and colleges, self-defence training should come first, and along with it the observance of brahmacharya."

See God in All, but Do Not Treat All Alike

**vidyā-vinaya-sampanne brāhmaṇe gavi hastini
śuni caiva śva-pāke ca paṇḍitāḥ sama-darśinaḥ**

"The wise see with an equal eye a learned and
humble brahmin, a cow, an elephant, a dog and an
outcaste."

— Bhagavad Gita 5.18

"'Seeing God in all' is said, but 'behaving toward all as
God' is not said — remember this. ... A lion is standing in
front of you — is God in it or not? He is. Go and bow to it
saying 'O Lord', and see. ... You have come to know that
Brahman is in it, but it has not come to know that you
are Brahman."

"That is why it is said there — 'treat on merit'."

The Lord Himself says in the Gita (4.11) — "**ye yathā māṁ
prapadyante tāṁs tathaiva bhajāmy aham**", as people
approach Me, so do I respond to them — but this is not "tit
for tat":

"Would our God be so small? ... He says that I will uplift you like a 'Mauli' (mother). I will not give up that quality of mine, but I will adopt a method suited to what you are. ... Some understand only after being beaten, some by being explained to, some by being given wealth. This discerning intelligence should come within us."

11. Woman: Every Form of the Goddess

Why do modern women stay away from ashrams? According to Acharya Ji, because only one form of spirituality was presented — white clothes, ash, sandalwood — while "a woman's nature is like Prakriti itself — colourful." The Durga Saptashati sees the Devi in every woman:

"Among them there will be a big entrepreneur (businesswoman) too. Is she not a form of Mahalakshmi? Should she then just apply ash and sit? ... A woman is in the army, in the police — is she not a form of Kali?"

"I am the only guru in India who says openly in discourses that even a woman who wears powder and lipstick can attain moksha. ... But will one attain moksha just by applying lipstick and powder?" — for that, one must learn Vedanta.

Gentle and Fierce: Each in Its Place

Vivekananda and Lokmanya Tilak feared that if women went out without understanding Vedanta, they could fall. Acharya Ji says:

"The Durga Saptashati says — the Devi's form is extremely gentle and also extremely fierce. Because Vedanta was not understood, the opposite happened — at home, before the husband, they became fierce, and outside, where wrong is seen happening, where one should oppose, they became gentle."

"What she should have done was — be extremely gentle inside the home, and outside, wherever she sees someone stepping in the wrong direction, take on an extremely fierce form. That would have been understanding the true meaning of Vedanta."

Ardhanarishvara

"Until we reach the form of Ardhanarishvara, neither will equality come nor will India become a world guru. ... Gradually, as the qualities of the woman enter the man and the qualities of the man enter the woman, both have to move toward oneness. From the woman a little loving feeling should come, and from the man the qualities of firmness, discipline and steadiness."

Not Equal — a Thousand Times Stronger

"Women are saying — we want to be equal to men. I say — no. That woman was never equal to man; she was a thousand times more powerful than him. Who gave birth to that man? Woman herself."

"But when, at that very time, she did not teach him brahmacharya, did not strike him for his wrong step, that is when the mistake happened. ... The day women understand when and how they are a thousand times more powerful, everything will become clear."

"It is said that a pativrata woman has more power of austerity than the seeker who goes to the Himalayas to do tapas."

At the end of the discourse, Acharya Ji asks his listeners just one question — the same question this chapter asks its reader:

"Did you receive some new understanding, have an experience, undergo a change, or not?"

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 **The forms of the deities are symbols** — "sādhakānām hitārthāya brahmaṇo rūpakalpanā". Ganapati is discerning intelligence, the mouse is desire; worship without understanding the symbol is incomplete.
- 2 **Idol worship is a practice match.** Its goal is to see God in living people and serve them, and then to reach the formless. Work itself is worship.
- 3 **"Cut down Kali"** — not breaking the idol but seeing beyond it; the form and the formless should both be seen together.
- 4 **The three goddesses are the three gunas** — Mahasaraswati (sattva, white), Mahalakshmi (rajas, red), Mahakali (tamas, black). The gunas are binding ropes; all three are needed, but each in its right place.
- 5 **Varna comes from guna, not birth.** All four varnas are needed for every institution and nation, and in the varna system anyone can move up or down.

- 6 **Hanuman's answer is the key to every relationship** — in duality, master and servant; in qualified non-duality, the whole and the part; in non-duality, one Self.
- 7 **The scriptures speak of tendencies, not persons.** Drop the vibration of "we are backward"; awaken the Brahman-feeling. Conflict comes from the conflict of the gunas, and its solution is to go beyond the gunas.
- 8 **To become a world guru, balance is needed** — Kali's courage along with sattva's forgiveness, and forgiveness where tamas and rajas dominate. We will win not by the weapon but by the scripture.
- 9 **The result of sadhana must be visible.** From result comes trust, from trust faith, from faith knowledge. In today's age of intellect, spirituality must be explained in the language of knowledge and science.
- 10 **Mahakali is the sword of discernment** — first on one's own faults; then physical strength, self-defence, and the protection of institution and nation. See God everywhere, but act according to merit.

11 Every woman is a form of the Goddess — Lakshmi in the entrepreneur, Kali in the soldier. Gentle at home, fierce before injustice. Woman is not equal to man; she is a thousand times stronger.